a feature of Russian development, exacerbated by ongoing health blights such as deeply eroded social networks, illness and alcoholism. It seems clear that there will continue to be fewer Russians, and they will be less healthy, and this last predicament overwhelmingly affects those closest to the poverty line. Nicholas Eberstadt, who conducted a systematic demographic study in 2010, reached even more drastic general conclusions: 'Russia today is in the grip of an eerie, far-reaching and in some respects historically unprecedented population crisis. Since the end of the Soviet era, the population of the Russian Federation has fallen by nearly seven million. Apart from China's paroxysm in the wake of Mao's catastrophic Great Leap Forward, this is the largest single episode of depopulation yet registered in the postwar era' (Eberstadt 2010:281).

Though O'Neill, reassessing the validity of his BRIC concept in 2011, fully acknowledged this population collapse, he flatteringly referred to the efforts by the Putin and especially the Medvedev administrations to revert it, and stated his hope that the country might yet rise to fulfil the economic predictions he had made a decade earlier: 'Russia doesn't need dramatic growth rates, it just needs to avoid crises', no less (2011). The comment is worth pointing out because it reveals a critical indifference to the effects of neoliberalism on the lives of the Russian people, as well as betraying a naïve faith in the officially stated priorities of the Russian elite. As one finds out, O'Neill reserves a similar treatment for an additional condition obviously afflicting Russia today: a binary made up of political authoritarianism and economic corruption. These blots set Russia apart from the other BICS in important ways (both issues being singled out as primary by O'Neill and the Kremlin regime alike).

On corruption, Putin himself has spoken of it as an 'intractable' condition of the Russian state. So widespread is the problem that clinical metaphors abound: 'corruption is the most serious disease affecting our society', said President Medvedev on taking office (Holmes 2012:235). To the degree that it can be quantified accurately, Medvedev also pointed out that known levels of corruption were likely to represent 'only the tip of the iceberg' (Medvedev 2010). Undeniably, the actual yearly toll exacted by corruption on the Russian economy is extremely difficult to gauge and estimates range widely between 5% of GDP (Rosstat 2012) and 25%, according to a recent partisan report (Milov et al. 2011; see also Saratov 2012). In the meantime, Russia's indices of perceived corruption – according to Transparency International – have plateaued in the last two years, putting it around position 130 in the rankings (133 in 2012 and 128 in 2013) – generally well below those of China, Brazil or India. Where the money goes, corruption follows. In Moscow, the city's Prosecutor General Sergei Kudeneyev reported that in 2012